

Episode 76: Once Upon a Time... (47) – White Protagonist!?! The Launch of *COO*

As always, when it comes time to replace my computer, I agonise tremendously. It's kind of like... breaking up with a girlfriend you've been with for a long time, and the future with a new girlfriend...

"I thought we could be together forever..."

"I knew this from the beginning. No one can win against the flow of time..."

It resembles the ephemeral nature of love's end.

Ever since I started using computers for work, I've been using Mac. Windows just doesn't suit me, so it's been Mac all along. I'm using three desktop machines (Mac Pro) between home and work, and connecting them, the one I carry everywhere and use constantly is a Mac notebook computer, the PowerBook G4.

The PowerBook I'm currently using is my fourth generation. Purchased in December 2005. Actually, the keyboard and various other parts are already quite worn out, and last year I dropped it on the floor at Hong Kong airport, causing the case to warp... Even so, I've been struggling to keep using it, but with technology advancing daily and the data I handle getting bigger and bigger, the specs have finally reached their limit (tears). I decided to buy a new MacBook Pro.

If I endure and persevere, I could manage a bit longer. But I can't escape the inevitable farewell that's surely coming... You could call it lingering attachment, but my love for this "girlfriend" who's shared so much time with me is immense. The keyboard feel my fingers remember won't be forgotten immediately even when I get a new "girlfriend" (laughs).

If it were death by separation (breaking down and becoming unusable), I could give up more easily (←hey now).

I've been writing this entire series on that PowerBook, but from next time I'll probably be writing with my new "girlfriend."

Now then.

We were supposed to create advance image stills for *Coo: Far From Home* (Coo 遠い海から来たクー), but I was surprised when I saw the key frames Okura-san had drawn. What was depicted there wasn't the Japanese boy Yosuke, but a foreigner - clearly a white boy.

"Ah, this... actually there's talk of making the protagonist not Japanese, but a foreigner," said Imazawa-san.

When I asked about it, apparently this came from Kadokawa's side. Actually, this COO was intended for production not just for domestic Japanese release, but with North American and worldwide release in mind. For that purpose, it seemed they thought that having white parent and child as protagonists would be more acceptable in North America and globally than having Japanese parent and child.

So Yosuke had become a white boy.

Nowadays, having a Japanese protagonist would probably be totally fine, but back then there was this big barrier of language between Japan and overseas, and there were indeed such "barriers" in terms of racial visuals as well.

"Whaaaat!? Hmm..."

Well, it wasn't incomprehensible, but as a fan of the original work, I felt somewhat unconvinced. But anyway, it was work. I created a refreshing blonde boy with clear blue eyes. And delivered it.

Around that time, production of *COO* was progressing at a relaxed pace... or rather, stagnating. There were things like the producer, director, animation director, and art director going on location scouting to the South Pacific, but in any case, without clarifying this "racial issue," they couldn't work on character settings, or even the scenario itself.

Then after a while, word came from Kadokawa.

"Please proceed according to the original work. Japanese parent and child."

And so various things finally got started. This was the beginning of my long relationship with *COO*.

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